

FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 32

NEW JERSEY
WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — a cross-location dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside New Jersey's family courts and child-welfare system.

76

NEW JERSEY FAMILIES ON RECORD · 138 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 12 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING TIME

DATA AS OF
NOVEMBER 9, 2026

COUNTY LABELS REPORTED
25 SUBMITTED

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

NEW JERSEY AT A GLANCE.

Across 76 New Jersey families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED
138
75 of 76 families reported child counts

MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN
$245,750
median across 38 families reporting 3+ categories

MEDIAN MONTHS LOST
12
of parenting time

WENT PRO SE
63.2%
48 of 76 who answered; 36 of 76 ran out of money

SUBMISSIONS	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN	COUNTY LABELS REPORTED
76	1.8	75 of 76	25

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so New Jersey families — and families across every represented location — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

02 THE COST OF NEW JERSEY FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	49	$43,000	$182,853	$8,959,792
Lost Wages	36	$30,000	$74,211	$2,671,600
Other Court Fees	31	$6,000	$37,299	$1,156,266
Therapy / Evaluations	35	$5,000	$15,741	$550,950
Reunification Services	18	$500	$7,944	$143,000
GAL Fees	19	$0	$8,432	$160,200
Asset Loss [1]	35	$80,000	—	—
Median Family Burden (38 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	$245,750	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least $1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median ($80,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS



03 WHO IS REPORTING · NEW JERSEY

Most families documenting in New Jersey are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children. Percentages below use only families who answered that specific topic.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed	33	44%
Not provided	18	24%
Active case: progress being made	10	13%
Case closed: within last 2 years	6	8%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago	4	5%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS	34	45%
Family Court Only	32	42%
Unknown	7	9%
CPS Only	2	3%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)	1	1%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years	20	27%
5 – 10 years	15	20%
3 – 5 years	15	20%
Over 10 years	13	18%
6 months – 1 year	5	7%

CUSTODY STATUS

50/50 Joint	32	42%
Visitation Only	14	18%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access	11	14%
Full Custody	11	14%
Partial / Shared	4	5%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Bergen	8	14%
Morris	7	12%
Passaic	4	7%
Ocean	3	5%
Gloucester	3	5%
Monmouth	3	5%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)	21	28%
High Conflict Divorce	18	24%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)	11	14%
Other	8	11%
Other: (Short answer)	5	7%

04 PARENT VOICES — NEW JERSEY

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable New Jersey comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.

> *Created severe P.S.T.D in me my children and my children father.Agency should be Abolished The agency Abuses children and families.*
>
> — LISA

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Morris County and Judge Bogaard has destroyed my children and I financially emotionally and physically they protect abusers. My exhusband has friends that are politically connected and law-enforcement. They are all sons of Italy bothers. They are all working together selling [...]

— NEW JERSEY PARENT · ISABELLA

MORE VOICES FROM NEW JERSEY

Institutional Betrayed my children and myself with fake justice and no interest in being impartial. I am deaf Latina who doesn't speak English our abuser is deaf American born but nevertheless court has allowed his paralegal wife interfere and participate for him fully even [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Child support against my constitution rights tl with no jurisdiction and. hey're went against and siderb with false dyfs calls

— JOEY

Allowed a known abuser to put a survivor on the street and cause homelessness and take her children who endured every ounce of the abuse with her and leave them in the care of the person who caused the trauma and now uses them to exploit others, as weapons to hurt their mother [...]

— CATHERINE

The Judge kidnaps kids from the protective parent and gives them to the abusive parent.

— INGA

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *Took my children away based on a biased report without due process, dismissing the documented abuse. Permitted post separation abuse in the court for over a decade*
>
> — COLLEEN

Family court is criminal, destroyed my family, with no contact to my 2 grown children who still live with their father who is a lawyer. I learned family court law, wrote my own motions after 5 years of over $100,000+ wasted on both sides and became ProSe.

— LORI

New Jersey is supposed to be one of the most supportive states for autistic children, except for my children. Bergen County Family court has and continues to destroy my family's life, they have made child abduction, abuse, and neglect practically legal.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I see the trauma my children have suffered by me having just disappeared from their lives one day then seperation and visits. I suffered trauma. My ex wife has used the system against me butbit has affected our kids snd still is.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I lost my son for 4 years from Pa and them had to get switched to New Jersey I was forced to give my son to an abuser

— MAUREEN

They have systematic or trying to kidnapped my child an termination my rights when no investigation was done just threw me an my newborn in her case,took my child out the country to Canada against my will the judge allowed it and continue to when I'm against him leaving the [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Made me financially bankrupt living in a vehicle 3 years fighting for my kids and home I'm just a visiting father friend after 15 years of marriage and 7 years I was stayed home Dad and she fraud me she cheat on me she adultery criminal activity and her lawyers defending it and [...]

— RAYIF ATAY

The court took my two little best friends and tried to turn them against me! It's destroying parents but siblings too!

— AMANDA

They are taking children from the only source of stability they have and allowing a monster to manipulate and alienate them from their mother.

— HEATHER

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *I was threatened by CPS that they would take my children for neglect if I didn't leave the physically abusive marriage, and when I left and filed a restraining order, the Court forced visitation that was "supervised" by his brother. I now have to send my youngest child to visit [...]*
>
> — KRISTIN

Courtroom corruption, fraudulent court orders, child abduction and trafficking attempt, uncooperative law enforcement, denial and restrictions for family members in making contact with child while in DCF custody

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed me and everything I've worked for, being a disabled veteran I was never able to recover considering it's gone on 8+ years now and has psychologically damaged my children and took their faith away in their dad's ability to protect them which breaks my heart the most.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Permanently destroyed our bond Crippled me financially

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Judge heard "emergency motion" and made judgement though acknowledging the reason for the motion being filed was not true

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Due process violations, fraud upon the court, open theft of assets. Protective parent targeted because I refused to sign away my children as wards of the state.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court has utterly failed my children and has purposefully ruined all of our lives to ensure they grow up in an unstable, unhappy environment.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Torn US apart - separated us I was a stay at home Mother housewife and homemaker.

— BARBARA

I thought the court system is meant to protect us, but it did the contrary, it destroyed us.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *Lost my home, 2 businesses, career, daughter now 11 in treatments for AMPS which can't be cured and primary compromised immune system so can't be in school. My child's life was destroyed with blatant lies, perjury, and malicious acts.*
>
> — CARRIE

No enforcement, judge stated multiple times "why is this case never settled. I'm not dealing with child support enforcement. Figure it out." Divorced with a 4 page binding agreement and no MSA. The judge would make a decision with a court order that would never be addressed in [...]

— ROBIN

Financial bankruptcy, homeless , living in a vehicle

— RAYIF

Separated all of us from each other

— LISA

4 months without a hug. None of this is fair

— ASHLEY

It was never about the children's best interest. As a resource parent for kin I was told by the caseworker, "stop trying to be a supervisor" when I asked too many questions.

— NICOLE

Defamation of character and the introduction of the system to my 5 year old only based on anonymous retaliatory allegations

— THERESA

This cost me a life of grieving my baby's who are still alive. The heartbreak makes it difficult to live life like I'm ok.... BECAUSE I AM NOT 💔

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I went through 4 attorneys, none of which were helpful in moving my case forward. One lawyer wanted me to hire a child custody expert and an educational expert to the tune of $80,000. I refused. My last lawyer cut to the chase, I cut my losses financially, and signed a terrible [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

> *Extended coercive control and allowed perpetrator to not only continue, but also intensify his abuse. Financially destructed us. Handicapped us from moving forward.*
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has torn my family apart. My husband and I both attempted suicide, we lost our jobs and are losing our home due to losing our jobs.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Caused considerable harm not in child's best interests and emboldened a HCBM to continue doing harm with no oversight.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Morris county family court has jailed mothers and continues to target them. See Richard Luthmanns articles for more information

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Vetting lawyers is challenging. Make sure you vet them. Don't get older lawyers who say the right thing but are jaded

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Profited off defamation, and never looked at evidence

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Created extensive delay of divorce with a high conflict other parent who continues their abuse post-separation. The marriage was emotionally, mentally abusive(& more), and the court allows him to continue abuse via financial and manipulation, due to the court's lack of action.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They don't look at my evidence I've been begging court that we can't coparent for years and they told me we need to learn however, my ex does not want to hate me and uses the kids as weapons

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Broken us and broken a beautiful boy away from a loving fully dedicated mother

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

52 New Jersey parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 42 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — NEW JERSEY

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from New Jersey families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

> Created severe P.S.T.D in me my children and my children father.Agency should be Abolished The agency Abuses children and families.
>
> — LISA

> Institutional Betrayed my children and myself with fake justice and no interest in being impartial. I am deaf Latina who doesn't speak English our abuser is deaf American born but nevertheless court has allowed his paralegal wife interfere and participate for him fully even though there are proof in writing that texts in app court are not his, nor long email with legal jargon to parent coordinators. In court his appearance are brief and fall short of his long demanding perjury claims on me. But nobody cares. I have requested to go onto mediation in court as both of us are in front of interpreter and mediator and his tantrums don't work and we are able to move on because his paralegal wife is not there to coach him but firstly attorneys don't want to suggest it and judge said they rather us to work it out outside court. But this leave us to the escalation of issues from our abuser for everything and for minimal it could be because he thrive in coercive control and litigation. He has told our children he will never stop fighting me until they are out of family court system and discouraged them to pursue college or university studies as he JW and wants them to go to mission and get married.
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> — JOEY

> Allowed a known abuser to put a survivor on the street and cause homelessness and take her children who endured every ounce of the abuse with her and leave them in the care of the person who caused the trauma and now uses them to exploit others, as weapons to hurt their mother, his image to cover the years of abuse and substance use, took my entire life and discard me like garbage when he didn't need anything anymore than dismantled my entire life, discredited my parenting and smeared my name. Rebuilt my entire life and he lied lied lied again to forced our children back into his care with an active temporary restraining order!!!!!!!
>
> — CATHERINE

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Morris County and Judge Bogaard has destroyed my children and I financially emotionally and physically they protect abusers. My exhusband has friends that are politically connected and law-enforcement. They are all sons of Italy bothers. They are all working together selling divorces and painting women as the “abusers” yet we are the ones with the actual physical evidence of abuses that the courts won’t review or allow into evidence. It is a white male misogynistic world in Morris County. It’s no surprise that all the ICE protests are currently going on in Morristown Because women , children, people of color are considered second class citizens in that part of New Jersey. I had an interview with Marianne Petrii with slam the gavel. To see my interview, just go to YouTube and search Isabella Reyes Alfano..

— ISABELLA

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I was threatened by CPS that they would take my children for neglect if I didn’t leave the physically abusive marriage, and when I left and filed a restraining order, the Court forced visitation that was “supervised” by his brother. I now have to send my youngest child to visit her abusive father, and have to spend thousands of dollars divorcing him, and attempting to get normal child support since the restraining order judge refused to review any of my evidence for support, or child safety.

— KRISTIN

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I went through 4 attorneys, none of which were helpful in moving my case forward. One lawyer wanted me to hire a child custody expert and an educational expert to the tune of $80,000. I refused. My last lawyer cut to the chase, I cut my losses financially, and signed a terrible unfair agreement (unfair child support, alimony, division of assets (including vehicles and retirement)) to stop from digging my debt hole even further down. Judge wouldn't even take the time to meet with the parties, and really didn't have time to meet with the lawyers. Spent a ridiculous amount of time with a mediator, paying 1.5x's my lawyers hourly rate, and nothing was accomplished. All of those "intensive settlement conference" days in the courthouse were a waste of time and money- we had nowhere to go and meet and figure things out. Plus, it was high conflict, so it was lawyers just arguing and not moving forward.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The system is being very biased. I explain to the court how the child is being used as a weapon to hurt me by the other party & they are doing nothing about it. I try to request more time other party objects and the court granted her objection. I been the one filing for 4 years and the other party is always talking about my personal life and mentioning how she do not want my fiancee to post my child on social media with out the court finding any harm. Judge Tiscornia still put that as an order mind you the other party never filed for that. This was a case I filed for. The system is being very unfair. Things keep getting worse and the court keeps enforing me to speak to the other parent despite the fact that they disrespect me.

— CHRISITAN

The family court system has turned my daughter's childhood into years of litigation, conflict, and instability. Instead of protecting our parent-child relationship, I believe it allowed repeated interference with my parenting time, ignored evidence I presented, delayed decisions, and left me fighting to remain an active father. The emotional, financial, and psychological toll has been devastating. My daughter has lost valuable time with her father that can never be replaced, and our family has suffered because the system failed to act when it mattered most. My goal has never been to "win" against the other parent, it has always been to protect my daughter and preserve her right to have a meaningful relationship with both parents.

— WILLIAM

The system took me away from my children even though I was their primary caregiver, the parent who took them to school, attended meetings, helped with homework, and supported their activities. Years of delays and litigation kept me from being an active father, while my children's education and well-being suffered, leaving us with lasting emotional and financial damage.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has re traumatized me over and over again, kept my family broken, and caused distress for my child. This system has brought me to the edge of what I can handle financially and mentally and then punished me for being a human being. This husband has allowed a party with coercive control history to keep harming me and my child.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

They have allowed my x to violate the court orders without consequence. Allowed him to retain shared custodies to continue to tell the children lies about me to place them in the middle of litigations and attempt to turn them against me and make their entire childhood an attack on me to validate his narrative to the end of our relationship.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

System allows people to become bankrupt by assigned all of these unnecessary evaluators and professionals. No cap on fees and no oversight and no guard rails for these unscrupulous individuals to get rich. It is appalling that they have such power over children and families while not following the law, bankrupting and colluding

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has destroyed the well bring and emotion state of my family. It has completely alienated my daughter from me and forced my oldest son to be alienated from his father and his family. It has systematically broken us. We live in constant PTSD and live to defend and protect ourselves. There is no peace. It is now daily attacks. It is not sustainable.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system is so skewed for people with higher income or those who know someone in the courts or have some sort of power of their own. Poor, hard working people usually pay dearly, well off people that are abusive do not.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Every time I came to the system for help, they made my situation worse every time I went to a new person to help they made my situation worse every time I went to administrators a directors for help they still involved blocked information, lost paperwork, or also made the situation worse. My 21-year-old son committed suicide in October 2025 due to the fact that he was unable to come back home because of the instability from three separate agencies attacking me at once.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

> It became so bad that my oldest was suicidal. When I begged the courts, the lawyers, and most of all my ex for help because he was suffering, no one listened. Only when a school therapist came forward and said that he was in bad shape did everyone listen. This has beaten me down to almost nothing. How can I be a father when I cant even be a human on some days.
>
> — ANONYMOUS PARENT

52 full approved New Jersey comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a public, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this New Jersey report comes from New Jersey respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in New Jersey — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 76 New Jersey families reporting here are not the universe of New Jersey families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. Response counts and percentages use the number of families who answered that specific topic or financial field. The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – November 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

Dollar fields exclude blank, negative, and obvious data-entry artifact values above the report's field caps. When asset-loss values contain a strong statistical outlier, the asset-loss mean and total are suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county or regional field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

STANDWITHMEG.COM | COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE.